

Deep Dive For The Whale

When: September 8th to 10th, 2012

Where: Sierra Nevada, Marvin Pass trailhead

Who: Matthew Hengst, Jen Blackie, Amin Faraday

Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157631512525444/>

GPS Track: http://farm9.staticflickr.com/8034/7976681627_1e229f3e7a_o.jpg

Stats: Day 1: 18.6 miles, 3000'

Day 2: 12 miles, 3600'

Day 3: 18.5 miles, 3000'

With my mystery illness seemingly behind me and a big Utah trip coming up quick I needed to get out and stretch my legs and see how bad I'd fallen behind. Whaleback (and originally Glacier Ridge) was going to be the perfect trip to do that.



Not bad looking. Of course the peak is about 25 miles in from the nearest trailhead so we were going to have a bit of a hoof in to fit it in the 3 days I had off work.

The plan was to hike in 20-ish miles with full packs to camp around Big Wet Meadow, wake up the next day and grab both Whaleback and Glacier Ridge, then hike out the following day. Long but perfectly doable if everything went smoothly.

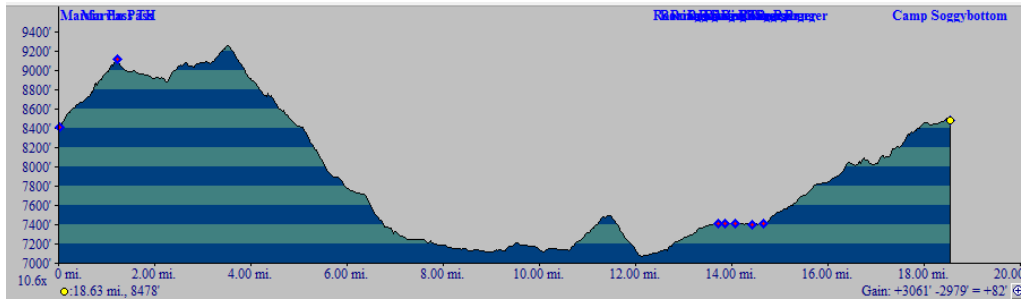


Yea, about that...

Whaleback is in Sequoia National Park and we'd be coming in from the west side so in addition to a long drive we were going to need to get the permit in person wither before 4:30 pm or after 8 am since the National Park Service sadly doesn't allow after hours permit pickups.

Jen and I drove up Friday night and stayed off a dirt road near the park entrance while Amin came up from San Diego and stayed at the trailhead.

Day 1: Bloody NPS Permits, Marvin Pass TH to Past Roaring River



Other than an owl trying to suicide bomb us while driving in the winding roads the night before the trip up was uneventful and we got a decent few hours of sleep before making a mad dash for the Grant Grove ranger station at 7 am.





Jen and I sat outside making sad faces at the procession of rangers and maintenance staff coming in and out of the building to no avail. Finally a few minutes after 8 am after having us wait while he put up the flag and went to the bathroom the ranger opened the front door and issued us the permit I'd filled out paperwork and paid for 6 months ago.

Supposedly the in person pickup is required because the ranger can give you last minute information about backcountry conditions but once again they didn't have much to add to what I already knew.



We did however get into an interesting conversation about the fact they had lockers visible through the back door with large yellow signs reading “Hazard: Do Not Open. Do Not Use These Items”

Apparently the visitors centers used to use actual taxidermized animals for their displays before they were forced to buy expensive fake animal replicas. So those lockers are filled with dead squirrels and such.



Permit (finally) in hand we sped towards the trailhead where we found Amin, did our last minute packing, and headed off down the trail.



Other than a disturbing amount of fluffy clouds for this early in the morning the view was spectacular.



We headed over Marvin Pass and dropped down towards Sugarloaf Basin. After a few hours we all commented it was starting to feel like it might rain.



Jen even commented that a little rain might be nice considering the amount of dust and sand we were walking through.



This was horse packer territory so the trail was very dusty, had frequent deposits of horse poop and the associated flies, and was occasionally blocked off by crude gates.



Then sure enough it started raining.



We actually had a small bit of hail mixed in with the rain and it came down hard enough we stopped to pull out our rain jackets and cover our packs for a bit before it trailed off.

Eventually we reached the backcountry ranger at Roaring River



I ran up to the building as I was determined to have someone acknowledge the permit that had cost us several hours that morning and that we'd subsequently lugged all this way into the backcountry.



Ranger Cindy W was quite nice and we started chatting. When the rain started again we edged in under the front porch and Cindy shared some nice hot coffee. Then it got harder and we went inside for more coffee and chatted a while.



We kept waiting for the rain to break so we could get on our way but it just kept pouring. Eventually it was just raining lightly and we decided to make a break for it.



Sadly the break in the downpour didn't last long.

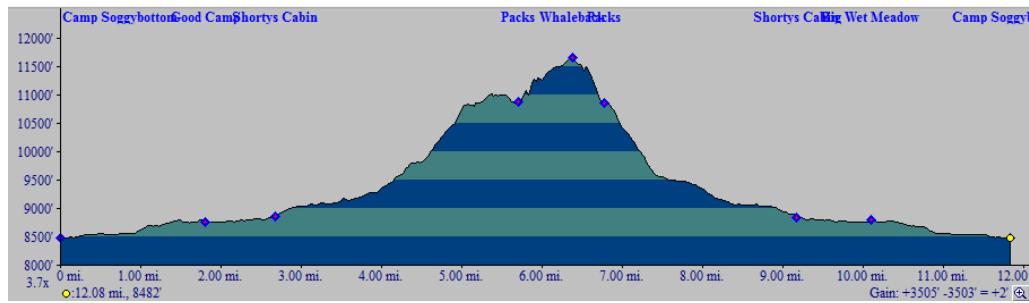


We kept going uphill towards Big Wet Meadow as the trail increasingly became a small river flowing the opposite direction. Eventually as it grew dark and the temperature dropped we decided to settle in for the night a mile or two short of Big Wet and just get warm.

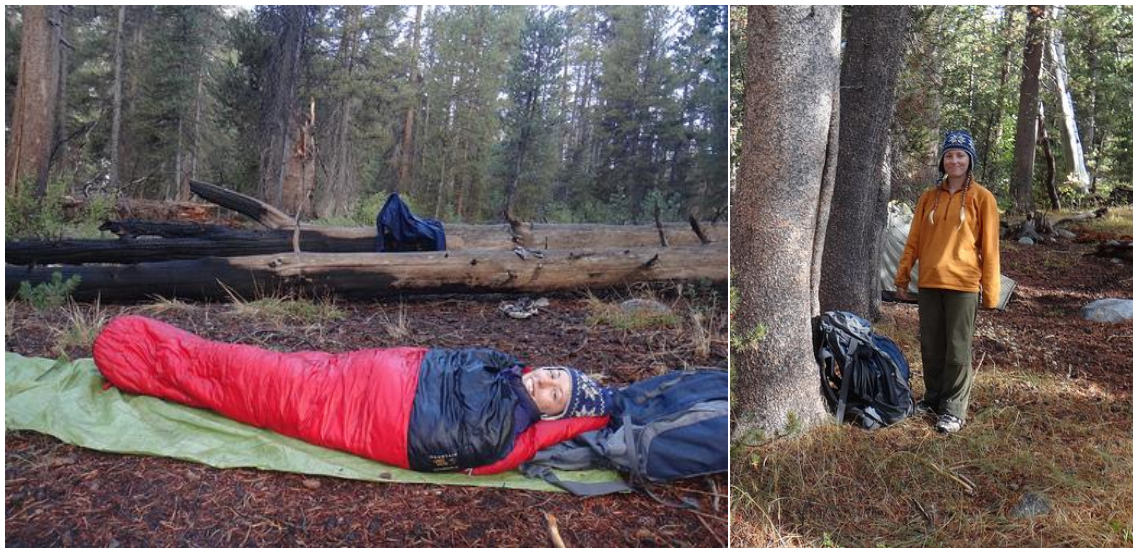


It was a rather soggy night. While the rain was pretty much done everything was soaking wet and water dripped down from the trees all night. Still, I've had worse nights.

Day 2: Whaleback



We had camped a little earlier than originally intended due to the bad weather and delayed getting up pre dawn due to the fact most everything was sopping wet.



We did get moving just as it was warming up and another mile or two down the trail and we finally caught sight of Whaleback.



Not bad!

We passed through the meadow commenting on the nicer campsites available but not really wanting to relocate several miles down the trail in the wrong direction.



We left the official trail where it swings east and continued south down Cloud Canyon.



From here it was a mix of boulder hopping and occasional use trails eventually leading to slabs on the southwest side of Whaleback.





We put on our helmets and started up the slope trying to follow directions from a previous trip report by Steve Eckert. We knew for sure not to go too far to the right where there were trees as that would force us to do a 4th class climb over to the eastern side of the ridge. We went up what looked like an obvious 3rd class route looking for something described as a blowhole.



We climbed up two different areas both times hitting 4th class bits I wasn't comfortable going over.



The weather was looking increasingly dire and after it started to rain lightly we decided to call it rather than risk having to downclimb wet slabs.



As we dropped down the weather cleared a bit and we headed a bit further to the north to check out something that looked promising. At this point we were basically just hoping to scout the route for next time.



And as it turned out that was the route described by Eckert. We took a look at the clouds and decided to try a fast run up the summit assuming it didn't start raining again. Jen went back to grab one of the packs and we hightailed it up the route.



The initial ramp leads to a short downclimb into an easy chute.



Up the chute you turn a corner to the left and from there we could see Eckert's Blowhole.



From here it's a nice ramp with a few 2nd to 3rd class chockstones to climb over.





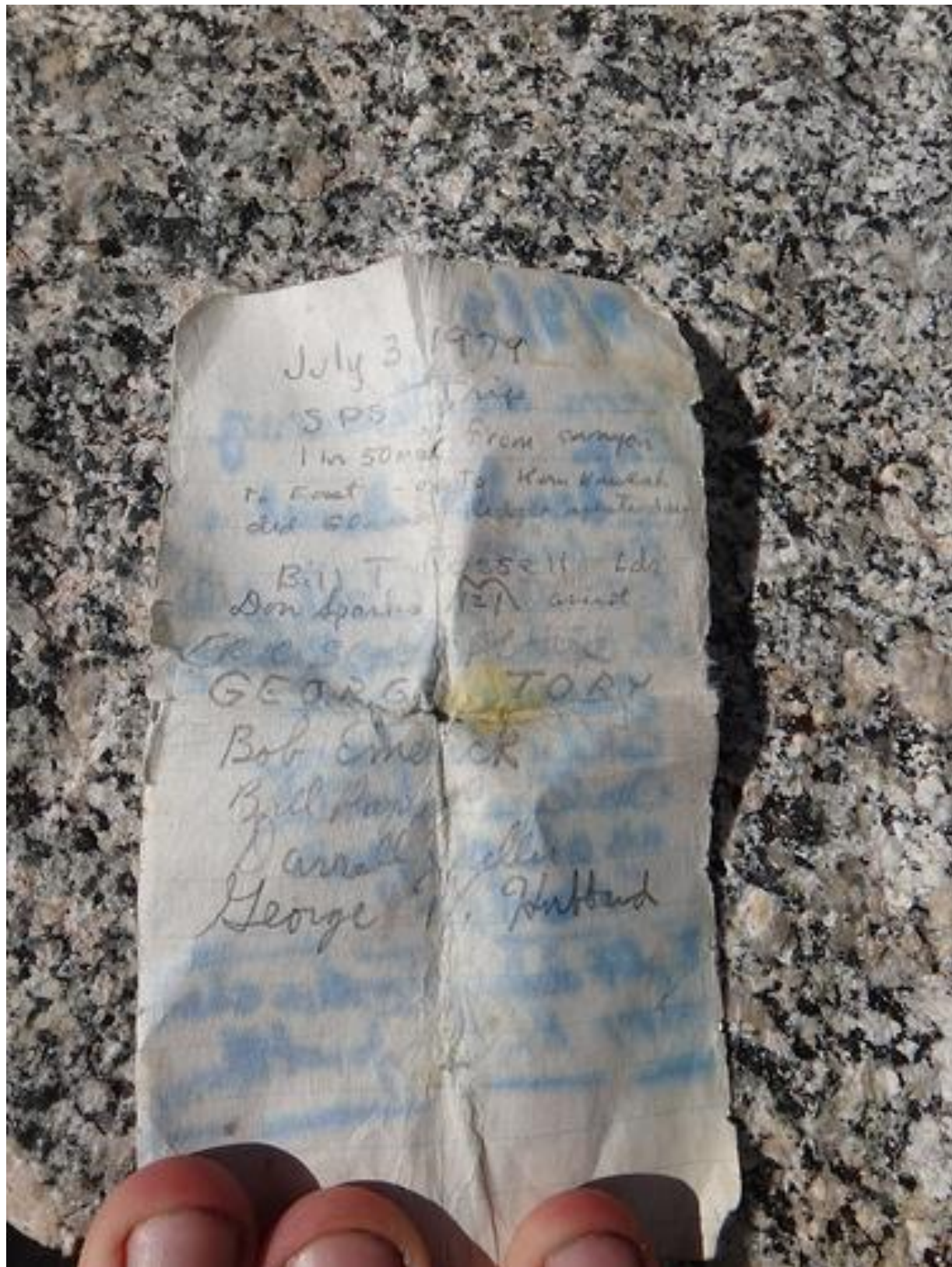
We hustled over them with one eye on the clouds.



Past that last chockstone we were home free.



The register had entries dating back to the 70s, not too bad.



July 3, 1979

S.P.S.

1 in 50 m. from canyon
To East - on To Kana Kana
did 50 m. from canyon

Bill T. Russell Lds.
Don Sparks 121 and

GEORGE TOBY

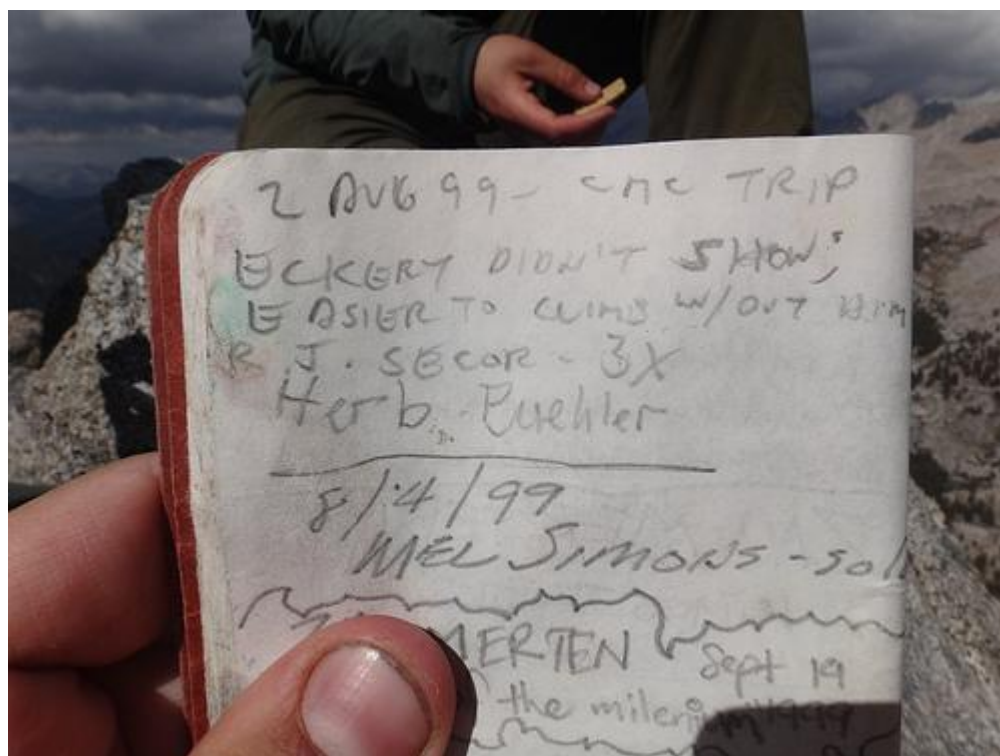
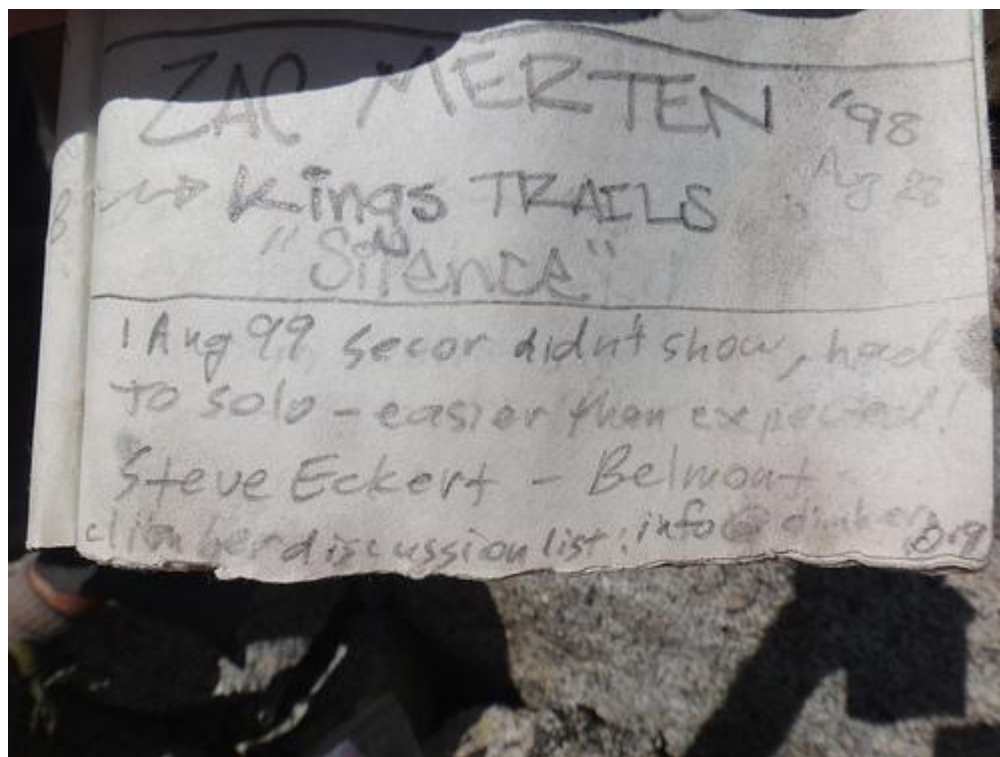
Bob Emerick

Bill Hanks

Darrell

George Hubbard

We also found the entries left by Eckert during the trip where he wrote the report we were using.





We took our pictures and decided it was time to get the heck down before the weather opened up on us again.





Down was easy with better views.





The route above Eckert's Blowhole viewed from above. You basically stick above the fins.





That's Jen on the ledge to the right.



The weather held and we made it back to the other packs without incident.



Sadly it was too late in the day to head for Glacier Ridge at this point but we did have some spectacular views of it with sun streaming down through the clouds.



We decided all our bad weather luck was the fault of the “lucky” Star Trek communicator badge Amin was carrying with him. Once it was left behind in the packs all the bad weather went away...



We came down and filled up at a nice stream before heading down towards Big Wet Meadow.





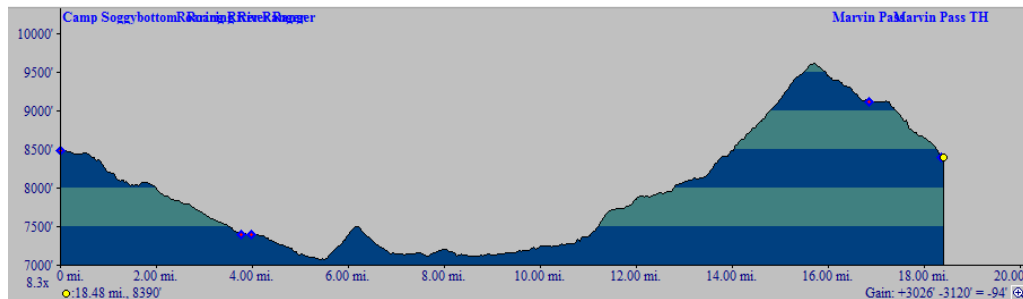
Back in the Meadow we came across an occupied camp with horses that looked rather familiar but no one in sight. We suspected it was our ranger friend from the day before but never caught sight of her.



It got dark enough we needed headlamps just as we were leaving Big Wet Meadow and we were in camp within an hour of that. Despite talk of relocating to a site with a fire ring so we could dry our things we pretty much decided to just live with wet bags again and crash.

It was a much more pleasant night this time as the trees weren't constantly peeing on us and our bags and clothing were only slightly wet. Luxury!

Day 3: Run Like Hell



We were camped about 20 miles in and had to concede it was unrealistic to make an attempt on Glacier particularly with the 6 or 7 hour drive waiting for us when we got to the trailhead. So instead we woke up and started heading out.



Things were thankfully mostly dry.



When we reached Roaring River the ranger station was shuttered lending credence to my theory the horses we'd seen were from our friend the ranger.



None of these are where we are going.

The hike out actually wasn't too bad with a lot of relatively flat (-ish) terrain until the very end. We'd talked about maybe trying Sugarloaf (the pointy rock in the foreground below) but I vetoed it after looking at how many more miles we had to go.



Again the weather held and we didn't even have any of the sprinkles from the day before.



Instead of returning over Marvin Pass the more popular southern route we decided to head north from Comanche Meadow and climb up to Kanawyer Gap. The trail had footprints but didn't show the same signs of heavy horse travel.



While most of our view was blocked by trees we did catch sight of Whaleback in the far distance.
(Highest thing with the surrounding ridge covered by shadow)

The 1600 ft up to the gap seems a bit on the brutal side with full packs and towards the end of our day but before long we popped over the top and dropped down into the meadows on the far side.



In addition to being scenic there were more gooseberries than I've ever seen in one place and a lot of the bushes hadn't been picked clean.

Marvin Pass was pretty much downhill from there and once we popped over that we were practically to the cars.



And...well..it's kind of embarrassing...



I know! Embarrassing isn't it? Back to the trailhead in the daylight. Carried that headlamp for nothing...

Fortunately we had a fairly long drive back and even had dinner at a rather skeezy Mexican food place in Cutler that I half thought might end up with someone shackled to a radiator. (Instead the worse part of it was some worryingly yellow carne asada and disappointing salsa.) We arrived home at the usual middle of the night.

I had some blisters but felt we'd done rather well considering the mileage and my enforced lack of activity. As a result we all decided to try for Picket Guard which was even deeper in whenever we could spare 3 days. Which turned out to only be a few weeks later...